

Document 6: Viral Gastroenteritis (Stomach Flu)

Metadata

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Definition of Viral Gastroenteritis

Viral gastroenteritis is an intestinal infection characterized by inflammation of the stomach and intestines. It is most commonly caused by contact with an infected person or through contaminated food or water (e.g., norovirus or rotavirus). It is not related to influenza.

Symptoms of Viral Gastroenteritis

Symptoms typically appear 1 to 3 days after infection and can range from mild to severe. They include:

- Watery, usually non-bloody diarrhea
- Abdominal cramps and pain
- Nausea, vomiting, or both
- Occasional muscle aches or headaches
- Low-grade fever

Treatment and Management for Viral Gastroenteritis

There is no specific medical treatment for viral gastroenteritis. Management focuses on preventing dehydration:

- **Hydration:** Frequent sips of water, clear broths, or over-the-counter oral rehydration solutions (electrolytes).
- **Diet:** Gradually ease back into eating bland, easy-to-digest foods (like the BRAT diet: bananas, rice, applesauce, toast).
- **Avoidance:** Dairy products, caffeine, alcohol, nicotine, and highly seasoned or fatty foods should be avoided until recovery.

When to Seek Medical Attention for Viral Gastroenteritis

A patient should seek emergency medical care if they experience:

- Inability to keep liquids down for 24 hours.
- Vomiting blood or experiencing bloody bowel movements.
- Signs of severe dehydration (excessive thirst, dry mouth, deep yellow or little to no urine, severe weakness, dizziness).
- A fever above 104°F (40°C) for adults.